

THE SOUTHERN CROSS

Crux



SIZE RANKING 88

BRIGHTEST STARS Acrux (α) 0.8, Mimosa (β) 1.3

GENITIVE Crucis

ABBREVIATION Cru

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 P.M. April–May

FULLY VISIBLE 25°N–90°S



Crux lies in a rich area of the Milky Way. Although it is the smallest constellation, it is instantly recognizable and is squeezed between the legs of the centaur, Centaurus. The longer axis of the Southern Cross, as Crux is popularly known, points toward the south celestial pole. Its stars were known to the ancient Greeks (see panel, below), who regarded them as part of Centaurus. They were made into a separate constellation in the 16th century.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

Alpha (α) Crucis or Acrux is the most southerly first-magnitude star. It is a glittering double that is readily divisible through a small telescope. The two components are of magnitudes 1.3 and 1.8. A wider 5th-magnitude star can be seen through binoculars; it is not related to Acrux.

The star at the top of the cross is the 2nd-magnitude red giant Gamma (γ) Crucis or Gacrux. It has an unrelated 6th-magnitude companion visible through binoculars. Nearby, Mu (μ) Crucis is a wide pair of 4th- and 5th-magnitude stars easily separated through a small telescope or even good binoculars.

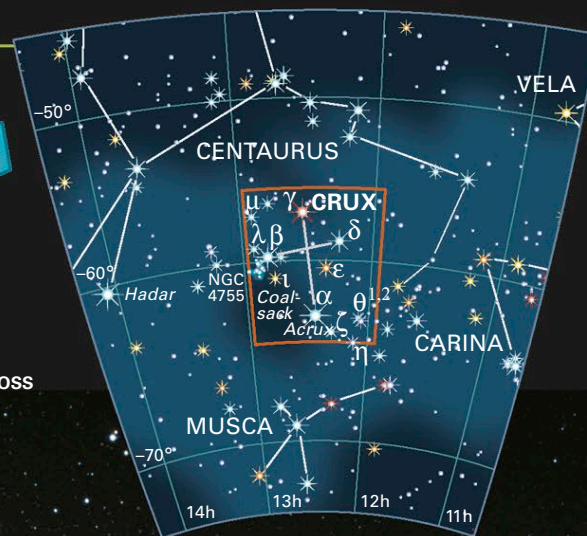
One of the gems of the southern sky is the Jewel Box Cluster (see p.294), or NGC 4755, visible to the naked eye as a brighter patch within the Milky Way near Beta (β) Crucis or Mimosa. Its individual stars, the brightest being of 6th magnitude, cover about one-third the width of the full Moon. They can be viewed through binoculars or a small telescope. Near the center is a ruby-colored

supergiant that contrasts with the blue-white sparkle of the other stars, producing a resemblance to a casket of jewels, hence the popular name.

The Coalsack Nebula is to be found beside the Jewel Box. This dark cloud of dust blocks light from the stars of the Milky Way behind it. It spans the width of 12 full Moons and extends into neighboring Centaurus and Musca, so is prominent to the naked eye and through binoculars.



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THE COALSACK ☞

The Coalsack Nebula, which lies next to the stars of the Southern Cross, is a smudgy cloud of interstellar dust silhouetted against the bright background of the Milky Way.

JEWELS OF THE SKIES ☞

The Jewel Box Cluster is a sparkling group of stars just north of the Coalsack Nebula, although the cluster is almost 10 times more distant from the Earth.

SIGN OF THE CROSS ☞

Four prominent stars make up the Southern Cross, one of the most famous of all celestial patterns, which appears on the flags of several nations.

EXPLORING SPACE

REDISCOVERING STARS



When European seafarers returned from exploring the southern latitudes in the 15th and 16th centuries, they reported stars they had never seen before. Among these explorers was Amerigo Vespucci (1454–1512), an Italian who in 1501 charted Alpha (α) and Beta (β) Centauri and the stars of Crux. Astronomers later realized that these stars had been known to the ancient Greeks but that precession (see p.64) had subsequently carried them below the horizon in Europe.

AMERIGO VESPUCCI

This imaginative view of Amerigo Vespucci observing the Southern Cross with an astrolabe was painted by the 16th-century Flemish artist Joannes Stradanus (Hans van der Straet).